“Needs More Help”: What That Phrase Really Means for a Family

A short guide to seeing day-to-day function instead of a diagnosis.

Somebody at the hospital said Mom “needs more help,” and then the conversation moved on. The phrase is true and nearly useless. It doesn't say help with what, how often, or from whom.

This guide explains what professionals are usually asking about when they talk about help, so you can describe Mom's days in the terms they use. It explains. It doesn't assess.

Start with the current picture

The first question isn't what Mom has. It's what her days look like now.

Medicare's discharge checklist asks patients and caregivers to go through everyday activities and mark the ones that need help: bathing, dressing, using the bathroom and climbing stairs; cooking, food shopping, house cleaning and paying bills; driving to appointments and picking up prescriptions. That list is a fair picture of what “help” means in practice. [1]

- Use what's true this week. If something was different before the hospital, note that it changed.
- Where you don't know, say so. “We haven't seen her manage the stairs” is useful information.

Everyday function has a vocabulary

Professionals sort daily life into two groups. Activities of daily living, or ADLs, are the basic personal tasks: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to and from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [2]

Instrumental activities of daily living, or IADLs, are what it takes to live independently: preparing meals, taking medication, shopping, managing money, using the telephone, light housework and getting around the community. [3]

Most long-term care, the federal Administration for Community Living says, is not medical care. It is help with those basic personal tasks. [2]

- For each activity, the useful note is what Mom does on her own, what she does with a hand, and what someone does for her.
- That's a description. A checklist of ADLs filled in by the family isn't a diagnosis or an assessment.

The health information you already have

You probably hold more than you think. Medicare's checklist tells families to ask for written discharge instructions and a summary of current health, to keep a full drug list (prescriptions, over-the-counter drugs, vitamins and herbal supplements, with any changes made during the stay), and to write down who to call with questions. Gather those. [1]

Medication questions go on their own list. The National Institute on Aging tells older adults not to stop a prescription unless the doctor says it's okay, and to talk with a doctor or pharmacist when unsure. That advice is written for the person taking the medicine. We'd hold a family helping with the pill box to it too: write the question down and ask, and don't adjust anything yourself. [4]

Getting ready for the people who assess

Two accounts matter, and they won't always match: Mom's own and the family's. The National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. Write her account down first, then what each of you has seen, with the date and who saw it. [5]

Medicare's checklist calls the patient and the caregiver important members of the planning team. The notes you bring are your contribution to it. What they mean is for the professionals to say. [1]

What this means for your family

- “Needs more help” becomes a list: which activities, how much help, and from whom.
- Your job is to describe, with dates. It isn't to conclude.
- How much care a person needs varies from person to person and often changes over time (source 6 below), so a description of this week is worth more than a guess about next year.
- The questions you can't answer by watching go to the doctor, the nurse, the pharmacist or a care consultant.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't explain any medical condition, say what Mom needs, or replace an assessment. The definitions and the lists come from the sources below. The advice about what to write down is ours.

Ready for the next step?

You can now describe Mom's days in the terms professionals use. The care interview asks about each of those areas in turn, so nothing important is overlooked, and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
2. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
3. Administration for Community Living, Long-Term Care Glossary
4. National Institute on Aging, Taking Medicines Safely as You Age
5. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?
6. Administration for Community Living, How Much Care Will You Need?

From the Family Care Roadmap · Richard Ladson, Certified Medicaid Planner. Draft for review, generated 2026-10-04.